

Word family: **then**

Base word: then

Part of speech: mainly adverb (副詞), also adjective-like use (定語用法) and limited noun-like use in expressions

Useful expressions: by then, until then, before then, since then, from then on, then and there, now and then, then again, if...then...

Your sentence:

> “**Then**, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the background.”

A full family sweep shows that **then** has several genuinely useful functions, although most develop from two broad ideas:

1. **a particular time in the past/future**
2. **what happens next or follows logically**

So this is a good polyfunctionality word, but we should not artificially split every construction into an unrelated meaning.

Meaning in your passage

Here, **then** means:

after the situation just described; next in the sequence of events.

繁體中文： **然後；接著；之後**

Natural translation:

> “Then, as soon as they put the headphones on...”

「**然後 / 接著**，他們一戴上耳機……」

So here:

then = 表示敘述中的下一步或接下來發生的事情

1. **then = next / after that (事件順序) — 然後；接著；之後**

This is your original meaning.

Practice 1 — Original

> “**Then**, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the background.”

「**然後**，他們一戴上耳機，周圍的一切似乎都退到背景裡去了。」

Practice 2

> “I finished work, **then** I went home.”

「我完成工作，**然後**回家。」

Practice 3

> “First press this button, **then** select the menu.”

「首先按這個按鈕，**然後**選擇選單。」

****then = 表示某件事情在另一件事情之後發生，是事件或步驟的下一項****

2. ****then = at that time (過去 / 未來某時) — 當時；那時候****

This is one of the main meanings.

Practice 4

> “I was working in London ****then****.”

「我****當時****正在倫敦工作。」

Practice 5

> “Things were very different ****then****.”

「****那時候****的情況很不一樣。」

****then = 在前文已經提到或大家知道的某個特定時間****

It often contrasts with ****now****:

> “Life was different then.”

= 那時候的生活不同。

3. **then = at that future time (未來某時) — 到時 ; 那時候**

Then is not limited to the past.

Practice 6

> “I’ll finish work at six. I can meet you **then**.”

「我六點下班 , **到時**可以跟你見面。」

Practice 7

> “The new system will be ready next month, and we’ll test it **then**.”

「新系統下個月會準備好 , 我們**到時**會測試它。」

then = 在前面提到的未來時間點

So:

* past then → 當時

* future then → 到時

Same core time-reference meaning.

4. **then = in that case / therefore (條件 / 推論) — 那麼 ; 既然如此 ; 因此**

This is a genuinely important non-temporal use.

Practice 8

> “If you’re tired, **then** take a break.”

「如果你累了 , **那麼**就休息一下。」

Practice 9

> “If the product really works, **then** the price may be reasonable.”

「如果產品真的有效，**那麼**這個價格可能算合理。」

****then** = 根據前面的條件、事實或推論，引出後面的結果 / 結論

Here it does not primarily mean “afterward.”

5. ****if...then...** (條件 → 結果) — 如果.....那麼.....

A very common logical structure.

Practice 10

> “If the battery is empty, ****then**** the headphones will stop working.”

「如果電池沒電，**那麼**耳機便會停止運作。」

Practice 11

> “If demand increases, ****then**** prices may rise.”

「如果需求增加，**那麼**價格可能上升。」

****if A, then B** = 如果條件 A 成立，就會 / 可以推出結果 B

In everyday English, ****then**** is often optional:

> “If you’re tired, take a break.”

But including it makes the logical relationship more explicit.

6. ****by then** = no later than that time (截止某時) — 到那時；到時候已經

Practice 12

> “I arrived at eight, but she had already left ****by then****.”

「我八點到達，但她**到那時已經**離開了。」

Practice 13

> “The project should be finished ****by then****.”

「這個項目**到時應該已經**完成。」

****by then = 以某個指定時間為截止點，在那時或之前某件事已經發生****

7. ****until then = up to that time (直到某時) — 直到那時；在那之前****

Practice 14

> “The office reopens on Monday. ****Until then****, please contact us by email.”

「辦公室星期一重開。****在那之前****，請以電郵聯絡我們。」

Practice 15

> “I had never used noise-cancelling headphones ****until then****.”

「****直到那時為止****，我從未使用過降噪耳機。」

****until then = 從較早時間一直持續到前面所指的那個時間點****

8. ****before then = before that time — 在那之前****

Practice 16

> “The meeting starts at three, but I need to finish this ****before then****.”

「會議三點開始，但我需要在****那之前****完成這件事。」

Practice 17

> “I had heard of the brand, but I had never bought anything from it ****before then****.”

「我以前聽過這個品牌，但在****那之前****從未買過它的產品。」

****before then = 在前面所提及的時間點以前****

9. ****since then = from that time until now/another reference point — 從那時起；自此以後****

Practice 18

> “I bought the headphones last year and have used them regularly ****since then****.”

「我去年買了那副耳機，****從那時起****一直經常使用。」

Practice 19

> “The company changed its strategy and has grown rapidly ****since then****.”

「公司改變策略後，****自此以後****一直快速增長。」

****since then** = 從前面所指的時間開始，一直延續到現在 / 另一參照時間******

10. ****from then on** = starting at that time and continuing afterwards — 從那時開始；從此以後******

Practice 20

> “I tried the headphones once, and ****from then on**** I used them every day.”

「我試過那副耳機一次，****從那時開始****便每天使用。」

Practice 21

> “From then on, she worked from home.”

「****從此以後****，她都在家工作。」

****from then on** = 以某個過去時間為起點，其後持續發生某個情況******

Compare:

* ****since then**** → 從那時起直到參照時間

* ****from then on**** → 從那一刻開始，其後一直如此

Very close, but viewpoint differs slightly.

11. ****then and there** = immediately at that exact time/place — 當場；立即就在那一刻******

A useful fixed expression.

Practice 22

> “I decided ****then and there**** to buy the product.”

「我**當場就**決定購買那件產品。」

Practice 23

> “She accepted the offer **then and there**.”

「她**當下立即**接受了那個提議。」

then and there = 在當時當地立即作出行動或決定，不再延遲

12. **now and then = occasionally — 偶爾；有時候**

We already encountered this under **now**, but it also naturally belongs to the **then** expression family.

Practice 24

> “I still visit that café **now and then**.”

「我現在仍然會**偶爾**去那間咖啡店。」

Practice 25

> “Everyone needs some quiet time **now and then**.”

「每個人都需要**偶爾**有一些安靜時間。」

now and then = 並非經常，只是偶爾發生

This is a fixed expression; **then** does not independently mean “occasionally.”

13. **then again = on the other hand / reconsidering what was just said — 不過話說回來；另一方面**

A very useful discourse expression.

Practice 26

> “The headphones are expensive. **Then again**, I use them every day.”

「這副耳機很貴。 **不過話說回來**，我每天都會使用。」

Practice 27

> “The café is usually crowded. ****Then again****, the coffee is excellent.”

「那間咖啡店通常很擠。 ****不過另一方面****，咖啡真的很好。」

****then again** = 在說完一個看法後，加入另一個可能改變 / 平衡前面判斷的考慮******

This is not temporal.

14. ****the then + position/status (當時的職位 / 身分) — 當時的****

Here, ****then**** functions adjective-like before a noun phrase.

Practice 28

> “The ****then manager**** approved the plan.”

「****當時的經理****批准了這個計劃。」

Practice 29

> “She met the ****then president**** of the company.”

「她見到了公司****當時的總裁****。」

****the then + noun** = 在所談論的那個時間點擁有該職位 / 身分的******

This is more common in formal writing.

15. ****then-current / then-existing / then-known (正式複合用法) — 當時現行的 / 當時存在的 / 當時已知的****

A useful formal extension.

Practice 30

> “The decision reflected the ****then-current**** policy.”

「這個決定反映了****當時現行的政策****。」

Practice 31

> “The research was based on the **then-known** evidence.”

「研究是根據**當時已知的證據**進行的。」

then- + adjective = 描述某事在所指過去時間點所具有的狀態

Useful in:

* academic writing

* history

* law

* journalism

16. **and then?** = what happened next? — 然後呢？

A very natural conversational use.

Practice 32

> “I put the headphones on.”

> “**And then?**”

「我戴上了耳機。」

「**然後呢？**」

Practice 33

> “She spoke to the manager.”

> “And **then** what happened?”

「她跟經理談過。」

「**然後發生了甚麼？**」

and then? = 詢問故事或事件接下來發生甚麼

17. **then** = linking stages in instructions/reasoning — 那麼；接下來

This lies between sequence and logical result.

Practice 34

> “Check the battery first. ****Then**** restart the device.”

「先檢查電池，****接著****重新啟動裝置。」

Practice 35

> “Once we know the cost, ****then**** we can make a decision.”

「一旦知道成本，****那麼 / 接著****我們便可以作決定。」

****then** = 把一個步驟、條件或推理連接到下一階段******

This is closely related to #1 and #4 rather than a wholly separate lexical meaning.

Important distinction: ****then** vs ****now****

****then****

= at the time being discussed, usually different from the present.

> “I lived there then.”

「我當時住在那裡。」

****now****

= at the present time.

> “I live here now.”

「我現在住在這裡。」

Your passage uses both words:

> “I still use them ****now****...”

versus:

> “****Then****, as soon as they put the headphones on...”

But these two occurrences have different functions:

* ****now**** = present time

* **then** = next event in a sequence

Important distinction: then vs after

then

is an adverb linking what happens next.

> “I finished work, then I went home.”

after

usually introduces a noun/clause or explicitly expresses a temporal relationship.

> “After work, I went home.”

> “After I finished work, I went home.”

So:

then = 然後

after = 在.....之後

They are not grammatically interchangeable.

Important distinction: then vs next

then

links one event to what follows.

next

more strongly identifies the next item/stage in a sequence.

> “First, press Start. Then select Settings.”

> “Next, select Settings.”

Both work, but **next** is especially common in instructions.

Important distinction: **then vs therefore**

In logical contexts:

then

= 那麼 / 那樣的話

therefore

= 因此 ; 所以, more formal and explicitly causal/logical.

> “If that is true, then we need to change the plan.”

「如果是真的，那麼我們需要改變計劃。」

> “The evidence was weak; therefore, the claim was rejected.”

「證據薄弱，因此該主張被否決。」

Then is much more conversational.

Important distinction: **then vs so**

This is especially useful because **so** is one of our remaining words.

then

in conditional reasoning:

> “If you’re ready, then we can go.”

= 如果你準備好了，那麼我們可以走。

so

often introduces a consequence:

> “It was late, so we went home.”

= 很晚了，所以我們回家。

They overlap around consequences but have different typical grammar.

Important distinction: **then** vs **afterwards**

then

often simply moves the narrative to the next event.

afterwards

explicitly means sometime after the event just mentioned.

> “We ate dinner, then watched a film.”

「我們吃完晚餐，然後看電影。」

> “We ate dinner and went for a walk afterwards.”

「我們吃過晚餐，之後去散步。」

Afterwards can suggest a less immediate transition.

Word-position note

Then can appear:

At the beginning:

> “Then we left.”

In the middle:

> “We then left.”

The second often sounds slightly more formal/written.

At the end when referring to a time:

> “I was living abroad then.”

So placement depends on meaning and emphasis.

Family-extension sweep

****Then**** has a very small true derivational family. Its richness comes from ****functions and fixed expressions****, not suffixes.

Useful modern set:

* ****then — sequence**** = 然後 / 接著
* ****then — past time**** = 當時 / 那時
* ****then — future reference**** = 到時
* ****then — consequence**** = 那麼 / 既然如此
* ****if...then...**** = 如果.....那麼.....
* ****by then**** = 到那時已經
* ****until then**** = 直到那時 / 在那之前
* ****before then**** = 在那之前
* ****since then**** = 從那時起
* ****from then on**** = 從那時開始 / 從此以後
* ****then and there**** = 當場立即
* ****now and then**** = 偶爾
* ****then again**** = 不過話說回來
* ****the then + noun**** = 當時的.....
* ****then-current / then-existing**** = 當時現行 / 存在的
* ****and then?**** = 然後呢？

There is no need to manufacture derivative forms that normal learners will never use.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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then — sequence	表示某件事情在另一件事情之後發生；然後 / 接著
then — past time	指前文已提到的某個過去時間；當時 / 那時候
then — future time	指前文已提到的某個未來時間；到時
then — consequence	根據前面的條件或事實，引出後面的結果 / 結論；那麼
if...then...	明確表示條件與結果的關係；如果.....那麼.....
by then	以指定時間為截止點，在那時或以前某事已經發生
until then	從較早時間一直到指定時間為止
before then	在前面所指的時間點以前
since then	從前面所指的時間開始，一直延續到現在 / 參照時間
from then on	以某個時間為起點，其後持續如此
then and there	在當時當地立即行動 / 作決定
now and then	並非經常，只是偶爾
then again	加入另一個可能修正 / 平衡前面判斷的考慮

****the then + noun****	在所談論的時間點擁有該身分 / 職位的；當時的
****then-current etc.****	在所談論的過去時間點正處於某種狀態的
****and then?****	詢問故事或事件接下來發生甚麼

For your original sentence

> “****Then****, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the background.”

The exact meaning is:

****then = 接著，在前面描述完嘈雜、擁擠和繁忙的環境後，廣告展示下一個畫面 / 事件****

So:

> ****Then, ...****

= ****「然後 / 接著，……」****

Here it is a ****sequence marker****, not the ****「當時」**** meaning of ****then****.